

Country music expands beyond its roots to reach mainstream audiences

Pop megastars are experimenting with country and bringing the genre to new generations of fans

Lesson #793

July 24, 2025

Filed: [Movies & Music](#)



Country music has long existed in its own space, with a dedicated fanbase and distinct sound. But recent years have seen major pop stars like Beyoncé and Post Malone embrace country elements, helping the genre reach new listeners. Streaming is also opening the door for more diverse artists and fans.

Transcript

Country music is growing its mainstream appeal

Country music is popular these days.

Country is a genre rooted in acoustic instruments and stories about everyday life—love, loss, and small-town struggles. It's [especially](#) popular in the southern United States and in rural areas. Country lyrics often reflect values like family and tradition—themes that don't always make it into mainstream pop. And

of course, they're often sung with a [southern accent](#).

[Kenny Rogers](#) sang about a veteran gambler giving advice to a fellow passenger on a lonely train ride. [Garth Brooks](#) sang about a man who looked back on a woman who broke his heart. [Dolly Parton](#) said goodbye to someone she loved but had to leave behind.

Country music has a unique sound, and it also has its own world. The genre has its own charts and dedicated radio stations. It has its own award shows, the Country Music Awards. While it's represented at the Grammy's, it has its own category. Only a small percentage of "country" songs get airplay on pop or rock stations. Its audience demographics are distinct from other genres.

Geographically, the heart of country music isn't in New York or LA, but in Nashville, Tennessee. The city is home to almost 200 recording studios. All the major country music labels are headquartered along Nashville's Music Row.

Country has its own unique fan culture, too. You can certainly find country music stars selling out arenas. But country music is often played live in bars, at county fairs, and in outdoor festivals.

For many fans, country music isn't just a genre—it's a reflection of their values and way of life. They're proud of their rural roots, and they like having music that reflects their values and lifestyles. They're fiercely loyal to their favorite artists, following them through long, multi-decade careers. Artists are quick to engage with fans on social media.

Country tends to grab the wider music world's attention when stars cross over into pop and rock. In the 1990s, for example, country singers [Garth Brooks](#) and [Shania Twain](#) reached the top of the charts in both country and pop formats.

In the 2000s, [Taylor Swift](#), [Carrie Underwood](#), and the [Rascal Flatts](#) found success blurring the lines between pop and country. Swifties who discovered Taylor during her pop phase often go back and listen to her earlier country albums with a new perspective. Country was also well-represented on the competition show "American Idol."

Still, until recently, it was hard to escape the sensation that country music was a world apart. But now things are starting to change. Country music is reaching new audiences, and some of its biggest songs are breaking out well beyond the traditional fan base.

Mainstream artists aren't afraid to experiment with country albums. Before, it was only country stars who evolved into pop stars. Now, though, some artists are going the other way: they start as pop stars, and then release a country album.

Beyoncé is a recent example. Her "[Cowboy Carter](#)" album was released in 2024—and it was a huge success. It introduced country themes to millions of music fans who might never have given country a second thought. "Cowboy Carter" [went on to](#) win the Grammy Award for Album of the Year in 2025.

Other non-country artists are riding the wave, too. Post Malone collaborated with singer Morgan Wallen on a song called "[I Had Some Help](#)" and is planning a country album. [Lana Del Rey](#) has released two country songs in advance of an all-country album expected soon.

Some country stars are putting their own stamp on pop songs from the past. Luke Combs hit the jackpot when his interpretation of “[Fast Car](#)” became an international hit.

Country listeners were also slow to join streaming platforms like Spotify: they’re loyal to their local FM stations. But data from the last few years show that country music streams are growing twice as fast as streams from the rest of the industry.

The move to streaming is affecting country stars the same way it has affected other musicians—both for better and for worse. Streaming algorithms often help fans of pop, rock, and R&B discover country songs they would not otherwise have had exposure to.

But streaming also puts pressure on artists to engage with their fans on social media and to make music that pleases the algorithms. And streaming doesn’t pay well, so artists have to first get popular on the streaming platforms, and then monetize with concerts.

Even with these difficulties, most artists think the expansion of the genre in the past few years is a good thing for them and for fans.

Jeff’s take

All right, so here are some country songs you can listen to. You may know better than I do the most popular crossover country songs that are popular today. But I’ll give you some more classic country tracks to listen to. Here we go.

“[The Gambler](#)” by Kenny Rogers. I mentioned that at the beginning of the episode. “[Travelin’ Thru](#)” by Dolly Parton. That’s a good one; that was from a [soundtrack](#). “[One of Them Girls](#)” by Lee Brice—I don’t recommend it for the grammar, but it’s a good song. And “[Springsteen](#)” by Eric Church.

So there you go. You have some country songs to listen to. If you listen to those, you’ll have a good understanding of the genre.

Practice reading in English

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[Berklee: Why Country Music is Topping Charts and Filling Arenas](#)

[Newsweek: Country Music’s Popularity Is at an All-Time High](#)